

LADY VICTORIA
designs

Before You Book the Venue

The Essential Wedding Venue Checklist

A COMPLIMENTARY GUIDE FROM LADY VICTORIA DESIGNS

A NOTE BEFORE YOU TOUR

The venue comes *first*

The venue is the first big decision you make, and nearly every decision after it depends on it.

Your guest count, your menu, your décor, your timeline, even the way your guests arrive: all of it has to fit inside the rules of the room you choose. A venue can be breathtaking on a tour and still be unable to support the celebration you are planning.

This checklist holds the questions our planners ask on every venue tour. Take it with you, ask the ones that apply, and do not pay a deposit until the answers that matter are in writing.



With care, Irene

IRENE NTIAKO · FOUNDER & CREATIVE DIRECTOR

START HERE

Before you contact *a single venue*

The venue search goes wrong when couples start by touring. Start by deciding. These five steps will save you weeks, and tours of venues that were never right for you.

01 **Choose your months, then your dates**

Pick two months you would be happy to marry in, then two or three dates inside them. Every venue conversation then starts with availability, not guesswork.

02 **Choose your area, wider than you think**

Pick a region, not a single city. In the DMV, that might mean Maryland, Washington DC, and Virginia. Two or three states multiply your options.

03 **Decide your style**

A hotel ballroom, a standalone ballroom, an industrial space, a barn, an estate or garden. And decide whether you want a space that is already beautiful, or an empty canvas to transform.

04 **Decide how your day flows**

Ceremony, cocktail hour, and reception all in one place? A church ceremony, then a reception venue nearby? An outdoor ceremony? These answers change which venues can work.

05 **Build your shortlist, then email, don't tour**

List five to ten venues that fit. Email each one with your guest count and ask for two things: a rough estimate of the total cost, and a video walkthrough of the ballroom.

YOUR STARTING POINT

My two months

My dates

My area

My style

My flow ○ All in one venue ○ Church + reception ○ Outdoor ceremony

My shortlist

THEN NARROW WITH FACTS

The estimates and the videos will cut your list to two or three serious contenders. Tour only those, in person, with this checklist in hand.

THE ONE RULE

“We’re flexible” *is not a yes*

Here is how it usually happens. On the tour, you mention that your caterer will cook on-site, and the coordinator smiles and says, “We’re very flexible.” Months later, the contract arrives, and it says outside food must arrive fully prepared. Nothing was promised in writing, so nothing was promised.

BEFORE YOU SIGN

If a promise affects your ceremony, décor, food, music, parking, guest count, budget, installation, or timeline, request written confirmation in the contract.



HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

One box, *three marks*

01 **Before the tour**
Read it through and cross out anything that does not apply to your wedding.

02 **On the tour**
Ask each question and mark its box. For starred questions, write down the answer and who said it.

03 **After the tour**
Copy every slash onto the Chase List at the back, and email it to the venue to confirm in writing.

04 **Before you sign**
Anything still not in writing becomes a change to request in the contract, or a reason to keep looking.

☐ **EMPTY**
Not asked yet.

☒ **SLASH**
Asked, and told yes out loud.

☑ **CHECK**
Confirmed by email or in the contract.

★ **DEALBREAKERS**
The questions that can end a venue. Get the answer and the name of the person who gave it.

VERDICT
At the end of each section, circle Clear, Needs follow-up, or Dealbreaker. Flip through later and see where you stand.

WHAT TO BRING TO THE TOUR

- Your guest count, and the most it could grow to
- Your wedding date, or the dates you are considering
- Your budget range for the venue
- Photos of your design inspiration
- A list of your ceremonies, traditions, and must-haves
- Your phone, for photos and video of every room, door, and entrance
- This checklist and a pen
- Your planner or designer, if you have one



01 Date, Hours & Curfew

Setup, the celebration, and cleanup all come out of the same rental hours.

- [ ] What time may vendors begin load-in, and when must setup be complete?
- [ ] ★ What time must music, alcohol service, guest activity, and vendor load-out end?

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] What overtime fees apply to event time, staff, security, cleanup, or late strike?
- [ ] Is there a local noise ordinance that ends outdoor music earlier than the venue curfew?

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

02 Real Capacity & Layout

The capacity on the brochure is usually for an empty room. Your dance floor, stage, bars, and décor all take seats away.

- [ ] ★ What is the realistic seated capacity with tables, stage, dance floor, bars, food stations, and lounge furniture?

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] ★ Can the full guest count fit in the weather-backup space?

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] If weather forces a change, by what time must the call be made, and are tents, sidewalls, heaters, or ground flooring permitted?
- [ ] Does capacity change for room flips?

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

NOTES

03 Alcohol, Bar & Certificates

Whoever holds the license decides who pours, who is insured, and when the bar closes.

- [ ] Does the venue hold the required liquor license, or is a temporary permit needed?
- [ ] Who obtains the permit, licensed bartenders, security, liquor-liability coverage, and certificate of insurance?
- [ ] Must the venue be named as an additional insured?
- [ ] What time must alcohol service end, and what bar fees apply?

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

04 Catering & Kitchen Rules

If your caterer cannot cook the way your menu needs, the meal you are picturing may not be possible here.

- [ ] ★ Is catering exclusive, preferred-list only, or open to outside caterers?

ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____

- [ ] May caterers cook on-site?
- [ ] Can dietary and allergy needs be supported?

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

05 In-House Rentals

"Included" can mean anything. Ask exactly what, how many, and in what condition.

- [ ] Which tables, chairs, linens, tabletop items, bars, staging, dance floors, lounge pieces, and cocktail tables are included?
- [ ] What quantities, sizes, colors, and conditions are guaranteed?
- [ ] Are delivery, setup, breakdown, cleaning, reset, and damage fees included?
- [ ] May the dance floor be wrapped or covered?

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

06 Décor Setup & Load-In

Your design is only as good as the hours and the access you get to install it.

- [ ] ★ Exactly how many hours are allowed for décor setup before guest arrival?

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____

- [ ] Exactly how many hours are allowed for décor breakdown and load-out?
- [ ] Can installation begin the day before, and may décor remain overnight?
- [ ] Is the space on the same level as the loading entrance?
- [ ] Is there a loading dock, same-level entry, ramp, or service entrance for large pieces?
- [ ] ★ Can large installations get into the room?

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____

- [ ] Is load-in easy for large pieces, or are there stairs and tight turns?
- [ ] What time must the room be guest-ready?
- [ ] Are real-flame candles allowed, and what enclosure rule applies?
- [ ] What may be attached to walls, ceilings, and floors, and are tape, pins, hooks, confetti, loose petals, or sparklers restricted?

Leave the technical side to your designer. *Measuring the load-in path, rigging, power, and freight are their job, not yours on a tour.*

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

NOTES

07 Power, Rigging & Effects

Lighting, music, chandeliers, and first-dance effects all need power and permission.

- [ ] How much electrical power is available for lighting, entertainment, catering, and production?
- [ ] ★ May chandeliers, florals, draping, or installations be hung from the ceiling?

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] Are cold-spark machines permitted?
- [ ] Is a low-lying cloud effect permitted for the first dance?
- [ ] Is atmospheric haze permitted for lighting and photography effects?
- [ ] Is there backup power?

VERDICT ◯ Clear ◯ Needs follow-up ◯ Dealbreaker



08 Guest Parking, Valet & Arrival

Arrival is your guests' first impression. A long walk in the rain is hard to undo.

- [ ] How many guest parking spaces are available?
- [ ] Is parking complimentary, validated, or paid by guests?
- [ ] Is valet required or optional, and what is the fee?
- [ ] Where are the guest drop-off, accessible drop-off, shuttle, bus, limousine, and rideshare areas?
- [ ] Is overflow parking available, and is a shuttle required?
- [ ] Is the path from parking safe, accessible, and well lit in bad weather?

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

09 Total Cost & Contract

The quote is rarely the total. Every fee you do not ask about shows up later.

- [ ] ★ Does the quote include the venue fee, service charges, taxes, staffing, security, cleaning, rentals, parking, valet, power, overtime, and damage deposits?

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____

- [ ] Does the contract list setup and breakdown hours, loading access, parking, curfew, catering, alcohol, weather, and overtime terms?
- [ ] Will every important approval be placed in writing?
- [ ] ★ What deposit and payment schedule does the venue require, and what are the cancellation and postponement terms?

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

NOTES

AFTER THE TOUR

Your *Chase List*

Copy every question you marked with a slash: asked, but not yet in writing. Email the list to the venue and ask them to confirm each answer. Check each one off as it comes back.

QUESTION	WHO SAID IT	IN WRITING
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		☐

TO SEND WITH IT

"Thank you for the tour. Before we move forward, could you confirm the following by email?"

IF YOU HEAR THIS, SLOW DOWN

Venue *Red Flags*

- "We're flexible," with no written detail behind it.
- Only an hour or two to set up décor before guests arrive.
- No one can tell you if large installations can get in and be set up in time.
- The weather-backup space cannot hold your full guest count.
- The quote leaves out service charges, tax, security, or overtime.
- Guest parking or valet cannot handle your guest count.
- Hanging installations, candles, or effects in your design are not permitted.
- The venue will not put an approval in the contract.

THE LAST STEP

Before You Sign

01 Request a complete itemized proposal.

02 Have your designer walk and measure the load-in path from the truck to the room.

03 Confirm setup and breakdown hours in the contract.

04 Confirm guest parking, valet, accessible drop-off, rideshare, shuttle, and vendor parking.

05 Review the venue with your planner, caterer, designer, and entertainment team.



LADY VICTORIA
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Lady Victoria Designs provides luxury wedding planning and full-room event design with thoughtful logistics, strong client advocacy, refined aesthetics, and celebrations that honor each couple's priorities and traditions.

Touring venues and want a second set of eyes? We invite you to schedule a design consultation.

Bring this checklist and your venue contract — we will review the answers with you and help you confirm the venue can support the celebration you are envisioning.

SCHEDULE A CONSULTATION

TEXT	(301) 312-0332
ONLINE	ladyvictoriadesigns.com

